Matilda, the ewe, lived a similar life. Drunky Monkey is another pet lamb, a survivor of twins, Drunky and Monkey. They had a traumatic birth and acquired their names when they struggled to stand for twenty-four hours due to extreme dizziness. About a year later, one of them dropped dead. Since they were identical, no one knew how to distinguish the victim. The lucky one inherited both names.

That sort of practicality sums up farm life, which grew on me quickly. Pet lambs aside, the family lamb around 2,000 sheep with a further flock that do not lamb. It's a serious enterprise on the mixed farm and I learned to take things in my stride, especially during lambing season. The first ten days of life are the most critical, so prompt attention, however improvised, is important.

Like most sportsmen, I love my food. I walked into Alice's mum and dad's kitchen one Sunday evening and had my appetite whetted by the smell of pork, roasting in the top oven of the Aga. However, I then saw, to my great surprise, a lamb sitting in the warming oven, wrapped in a towel to keep it warm. I'd never seen anything like it, though for Alice's family it is second nature to do anything to keep a lamb alive.

It was suffering from hypothermia, one of the biggest dangers for new-born lambs, and to keep them warm is vital in those first few hours. Older sheep produce body heat from digesting their food and have thick wool. Lambs are vulnerable, since the so-called 'brown fat' they are born with will only keep them alive for a few hours. Common-sense care, especially on a Sunday with the roast dinner almost ready, is why that lamb was sitting in the Aga!

For five weekends during the lambing season the farm is open for families to come and see the farm in action. I always find it fascinating chatting to people who, like me, have had no farming experience and through these few days get to see the caring nature of farmers, which isn't often talked about.

Farming gives me perspective. It has helped to shape me and provides an antidote to the shallowness of celebrity and scrutiny that comes with top-class sport. Don't get me wrong: I'm grateful for the material rewards and personal satisfaction cricket has given me, but they need to be balanced with an awareness of the world that is around me.

I still joke with my father-in-law that I've never done a proper day's work in my life. I've farmed and played cricket. Though we both know that